

New Generation English B· Diagnostic Test

C1 (Advanced Academic) B· Reading

READING

The paradox of expertise: why specialists often see less

There is a particular irony in advanced professional knowledge: the more an expert knows about a narrow subject, the more they begin to see only that subject. A radiologist who has reviewed ten thousand chest X-rays develops an exceptional eye for chest pathology and a measurable blind spot for anomalies in other parts of the same image. A senior litigator who has won hundreds of cases on procedural grounds will, even unconsciously, frame new disputes in procedural terms. The expertise produces depth at the cost of width.

This is not a personal failing. It is a structural feature of how human attention works at high levels of specialisation. The brain, presented with familiar patterns, recognises them faster than it questions them. That speed is precisely what makes an expert useful in their domain. But the same speed becomes a liability the moment the problem in front of them is not exactly the one their experience predicts.

The practical lesson is not that expertise is unreliable. It clearly is reliable, within its proper domain. The lesson is about how expert advice should be requested and how it should be received. A wise client does not ask a single specialist to interpret a complicated situation; they ask two or three, ideally from neighbouring fields. A wise expert, in turn, names the limits of their own perspective without apology, treating those limits as professional information rather than weakness.

The deeper, less comfortable implication concerns the institutions that train experts. Most professional education rewards the deepening of a chosen field, not the cultivation of awareness about its blind spots. Doctors are not formally trained in the psychology of medical error. Lawyers are not formally trained in the limits of their own argumentation styles. Where such training does exist, it is usually optional, marginal and easy to ignore. As a result, the paradox of expertise reproduces itself, generation after generation, in fields that genuinely need it discussed.

1. What "particular irony" does the writer identify in advanced professional knowledge?

A) The more an expert knows about a narrow subject, the more they begin to see only that subject.

B) Experts are always wrong.

C) Knowledge has no link with attention.

2. What does the radiologist example illustrate?

A) A blind spot for anomalies outside the chest, despite extreme skill within it.

B) Perfect general vision.

C) An unrelated medical phenomenon.

3. How does the brain handle familiar patterns?

A) It refuses to recognise them.

B) It recognises them faster than it questions them.

